CONTENT STRATEGY — 2026 EDITION

The Tournament Format: How to Go Viral in 90 Seconds

The complete guide to the bracket content format dominating TikTok and Reels — 35 ready-to-film ideas, the full AI script generator, and filming tips.

7	35	6	€0
NICHES	TOPIC IDEAS	CHAPTERS	COST

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CHAPTER 01

What Is the Tournament Format?

The Tournament is a short-video content format where **8 contenders** [illegible] **in a single-elimination bracket** — round after round — until one winner remains. The creator reacts to each matchup with fast, decisive commentary.

8	4	2	1
CONTENDERS	ROUND 1 DUELS	SEMI-FINALS	CHAMPION

Here's what a typical bracket looks like in action:

EXAMPLE: "WHAT'S THE WORST SUPPLEMENT TO WASTE MONEY ON?"

Collagen Powder
~~Testosterone Booster~~

Pre-Workout
~~BCAAs~~

SEMI-FINAL → Pre-Workout wins

🏆

Pre-Workout
BIGGEST WASTE

Detox Teas
~~Fat Burners~~

Mega-Dose Vit C
~~Homeopathics~~

SEMI-FINAL → Detox Teas wins

Why Does This Format Explode?

Three mechanics drive the engagement spike — and they're all backed by how platforms actually reward content:

TENSION

Brackets create natural suspense. The audience genuinely wants to know who wins. **Watch time stays high because viewers can't leave before the final.**

DEBATE

Controversial picks generate comments. When you eliminate something people love — or crown something they hate — they **must say something**. Comment velocity signals the algorithm to boost the post.

IDENTITY

People share content that reflects their values and opinions. A tournament about the best workout or the worst spending habit **feels personal** — it gets saved, shared, and stitched.

> *"The algorithm rewards watch time and comments. The tournament format is engineered to produce both."*

This is not a trend that will fade. Debate content has driven engagement since the first talk show. The Tournament format is just the 2026 version of a mechanic that's been working for decades — compressed into 90 seconds and optimized for vertical video.

CHAPTER 02

Step 1 — Choose Your Niche

Find the section in Chapter 3 that matches your expertise. There are 7 niches covered: Health & Fitness, Business, Finance, Interior Design, Real Estate, Beauty/Skincare, and Relationships. Each niche has 5 ready-to-use tournament ideas.

Step 2 — Pick a Topic That's Controversial or Misunderstood

> THE GOLDEN RULE
>
> Pick a topic where your audience *thinks they know the answer* but your take will surprise them. Controversy isn't about being offensive — it's about having a **strong, defensible opinion** that not everyone will agree with.

The best tournament topics share three traits:

- **Everyone in your audience has an opinion on it** — even beginners
- **There's a "trap" option** — something people think is good but isn't (or vice versa)
- **The result creates identity statements** — "I knew it" or "That's wrong and here's why"

Step 3 — Use the Framework to Script Your Video

Every tournament video follows the same structure:

```
HOOK  3-5 seconds
```

✅ "8 supplements. One winner. Let's settle this."
✅ "I'm ranking the worst spending habits — this will trigger someone."
❌ "Hey guys, have you ever wondered which..."

ROUND 1 — 4 DUELS 30-45 seconds

[ON SCREEN: Collagen vs Testosterone Booster]
"Collagen powder — at least it can improve skin. Testosterone booster — pure marketing."
[ELIMINATED: Testosterone Booster]

One verdict per duel. Max one sentence. No hesitation.

ROUND 2 — SEMI-FINALS 20-30 seconds

2-3 sentences max per matchup. Add substance and expertise here.

"Pre-Workout versus Collagen. Pre-workout has actual evidence behind it — caffeine, beta-alanine work. But the doses in most products are under-dosed and the crash is brutal."
[ELIMINATED: Collagen]

FINALE 15-20 seconds

"And now, for the finale..." *[Rising tension]*

"Pre-Workout versus Detox Tea. Detox Tea is literally a laxative in a pretty box. Pre-Workout at least gives you energy — even if it's mostly placebo. The winner: Pre-Workout. Biggest waste of money? Detox Tea. Every. Single. Time."

```
Option A: "What would you have put in the final? Tell me in the
comments."
Option B: "Tomorrow we're ranking the BEST supplements worth every
cent. Get ready."
```

SCRIPTWRITING RULES

Max 15 words per sentence. Spoken language only — read it aloud before filming. Zero filler words (actually, basically, so). Total spoken duration: 45–90 seconds. **Stand by your choices.** Hesitation kills the format.

CHAPTER 03

35 Topic Ideas by Niche

Use these as direct launch pads. The title format is: **"Which [WHAT YOU ARE COMPARING] is the best/worst for [RESULT]?"** — copy it directly as your video title.

HEALTH & FITNESS

01 — GLUTES

Glute Exercises

"Which of these exercises is best for building your glutes?"

Heart Health Foods

"Which of these foods is best for heart health?"

03 — CORTISOL

Cortisol-Spiking Habits

"Which of these bad habits sends your cortisol levels skyrocketing?"

04 — SUPPLEMENTS

Daily Supplements

"Which of these supplements should you take every day?"

05 — FAT LOSS

Fat-Loss Foods

"Which of these foods are best for fat loss?"

BUSINESS COACHES & CONSULTANTS

01 — AI

Business AI Software

"Which AI Software Is Best for Your Business?"

02 — PAYMENT

Payment Processors

"Which of These Payment Processors Is the Best?"

03 — BUSINESS TYPES

Business Models 2026

"Which Businesses Are the Most Profitable to Launch in 2026?"

04 — LEAD MAGNETS

Lead Magnet Styles

"Which Style of Lead Magnet Converts Best?"

CRM Platforms

"Which CRM Platforms Are the Best?"

FINANCE & INVESTING

01 — CREDIT CARDS

Travel Rewards Cards

"Which Credit Card Is Best for Travel Rewards?"

02 — STOCKS

Beginner Stocks

"Which Stocks Should You Invest In When Starting Out?"

03 — INVESTING

Return on Investment

"Where Should You Put Your Money to Get Good Returns?"

04 — SPENDING HABITS

Money Killers

"Which Spending Habits Are Keeping You Broke?"

05 — TAX

Tax Strategies

"Which Tax Strategies Save You the Most Money?"

INTERIOR DESIGN & DECOR

01 — DEAD TRENDS

Decor Trends to Kill

"Which Decor Trends Need to Die in 2026?"

Furniture Offenders

"Which Furniture Gives Your Interior a Cheap Look?"

03 — BUDGET LUXURY

Affordable Upgrades

"Which Affordable Upgrades Give Your Home a Luxury Look?"

04 — RENOVATION

ROI Renovations

"Which Renovations Add the Most Value to Your Home?"

05 — APPLIANCES

Appliance Brands

"Which Appliance Brands Are the Most Reliable?"

REAL ESTATE

01 — NEIGHBORHOODS

[City] Neighborhoods

"What is the most affordable neighborhood to live in near [CITY]?"

02 — RED FLAGS

Viewing Red Flags

"The biggest red flag to spot during a property viewing:"

03 — INSPECTION

Inspection Red Flags

"The biggest red flag to spot during a property inspection:"

04 — STAGING

Home Staging Techniques

"Which home staging technique sells your house faster?"

Real Estate Markets 2026

"What is the best place to invest in real estate in 2026?"

BEAUTY & SKINCARE

01 — TRENDS

TikTok Skincare Trends

"Which TikTok skincare trends are making your skin worse?"

02 — ACNE

Breakout Triggers

"Which bad habit causes the most breakouts?"

03 — MORNING ROUTINE

AM Skincare Habits

"The best morning skincare habit for fresh-looking skin:"

04 — SUNSCREEN

Sunscreen Brands

"Which sunscreen brand offers the best protection for your face?"

05 — UNDER-EYES

Under-Eye Patches

"Which brand of under-eye patches is best for dark circles?"

RELATIONSHIP & DATING COACHES

01 — RED FLAGS

First Date Red Flags

"The Biggest Red Flag on a First Date:"

Breakup Predictors

"What Is the #1 Sign a Couple Is Going to Break Up?"

03 — HIGH VALUE

Partner Traits

"The Best Trait to Look for in a Partner:"

04 — DATE IDEAS

First Date Spots

"The Best Place for a First Date:"

05 — GREEN FLAGS

Positive Signals

"The Biggest Green Flag on a First Date:"

CHAPTER 04

The AI Script Generator Prompt

Paste this prompt into any LLM (Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini). It will ask you 2 questions, propose 5 tournament concepts for your niche, and write a complete ready-to-film script.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Copy the full prompt below. 2. Paste into a new chat. 3. Answer the 2 niche questions. 4. Choose one of the 5 concepts it proposes. 5. Receive your complete

FULL AI PROMPT — COPY EVERYTHING BELOW

```
You are an expert in creating viral content for social media, specializing
in the "tournament" format (single-elimination bracket).

## The Tournament Format
The tournament is a content format where 8 elements compete in a single-
elimination bracket, round after round, until only one remains. The creator
reacts to each duel decisively and quickly. This format generates massive
engagement because it creates tension, debate, and identification.

## Your Role
You will help me create complete tournament content (idea + tournament +
script ready to film) adapted to my niche.

## Step 1 — Understanding my niche
Ask me exactly 2 short questions:
1. What is your niche or area of expertise?
2. Who is your target audience (typical profile, level, interests)?

Wait for my answers before moving on to the next step. Don't suggest
anything until I've answered.

## Step 2 — Proposing Tournament Concepts
Once you have my answers, propose 5 tournament concepts tailored to my
niche.

For each concept, provide:
- A catchy title (Format: "What is the WORST/BEST _?")
- The 8 tournament elements, organized into 4 first-round matchups (LEFT
SIDE: Match 1, Match 2 / RIGHT SIDE: Match 3, Match 4)
- A one-sentence explanation of why this concept will spark debate.

Rules for selecting the 8 elements:
- Mix obvious choices with surprising ones.
- Include at least 1-2 "trap" elements — items people think are good but
aren't (or vice versa).
- Elements must be concrete and visual (no abstract concepts).
- Each element must be limited to a maximum of 3-4 words (for on-screen
display).
```

```
- Place the most divisive matchups at the beginning of the tournament (to
hook the audience).

Present the 5 concepts in a numbered list, then ask me to choose one.
Wait for my selection before proceeding to the next step.

## Step 3 — Write the Full Script
Once the concept is chosen, write the complete script:

### HOOK (3-5 seconds)
- Ultra-direct opening sentence. Assertive tone. No weak questions.
- Patterns: "[Topic]: We're settling this today." / "8 [items]. Only one
winner. Let's go."

### ROUND 1 — 4 Duels (30-45 seconds)
For each duel:
- Announce the two elements facing off.
- Give your verdict in ONE sentence maximum.
- Be decisive and direct. Fast pace. No lengthy justifications.
- Indicate [TEXT ON SCREEN: "Element A vs Element B"] before each duel.
- State [ELIMINATED: Element X] after each verdict.

### ROUND 2 — Semi-Finals (20-30 seconds)
For each semi-final:
- Announce the matchup.
- Elaborate slightly more (2-3 sentences max).

### FINALE (15-20 seconds)
- Announce with rising tension: "And now, for the finale..."
- Deliver your verdict with a punchy justification in 2-3 sentences.
- End with confidence.

### CTA (5-10 seconds)
- Invite debate: "What would you have put in the final?" or
- Tease next episode: "Tomorrow we're doing [topic] — get ready."

### Scriptwriting Rules
- Use spoken language. Read it aloud.
- Max 15 words per sentence.
- No filler words (actually, basically, so...).
- Direct and assertive. You stand by your choices.
- Total duration: 45-90 seconds of spoken dialogue.

## Output Format
```

```
Present the script in clearly separated sections (HOOK / ROUND 1 / ROUND 2 / FINALE / CTA).

After the script, provide:
- 3 alternative hook variations
- Algorithm-optimized caption (with hashtags)
- A suggestion for a follow-up tournament topic (to build a series)
```

PRO TIP — SKIP TO STEP 3

If you already know your topic and your 8 contenders, paste the prompt and immediately add: *"Skip Steps 1 and 2. My topic is [TITLE]. My 8 contenders are: [LIST]. Write the full script directly."* This cuts the process to under 2 minutes.

CHAPTER 05

Filming & Editing Guide

The Bracket Visual

The bracket is not optional — it is the format. Without the visual, it's just a list. Create your bracket in **Canva** (free) or any video editor, then overlay it on your footage as a full-screen graphic or corner insert.

CANVA BRACKET TEMPLATE TIPS

Use a dark background (black or deep navy). Bold white text for names. Accent color for the winner's side. Cross out or fade eliminated entries. Keep it clean, max 3 words per entry. Export at 1080×1920 (vertical 9:16).

Camera Setup

- **Frame:** Medium close-up — chest to top of head. Face fills the upper 60% of frame.
- **Background:** Contextual is better than blank. Office (business niche), kitchen (health), gym (fitness), living room (interior design).
- **Lighting:** Ring light or window at 45°. No harsh overhead lights. Fill shadows on one side.
- **Eye contact:** Film to camera, not to your bracket. The bracket is a cutaway — you react to it, not read from it.

Editing for Maximum Retention

THE 3-EDIT RULE

Every duel should be: 1. **On-screen text reveal** (0.5s) → 2. **Your verbal verdict** (2-4s) → 3. **Elimination animation** (0.5s cross-out or fade). Total per duel: under 6 seconds. If it takes longer, cut harder.

- **Hard cuts only.** No slow dissolves between duels.
- **Zoom pulse on verdicts.** A subtle 5–10% zoom-in when you deliver the verdict adds emphasis.
- **Sound design.** A short "elimination" sound (buzzer, cross-out effect) when a contender is knocked out. Canva, CapCut, and DaVinci Resolve all have free sound packs.

- **Captions.** Auto-generate with CapCut or Submagic. Always. 80% of viewers watch without sound.
- **Final reveal:** Freeze-frame + slow zoom on the winner. Add a small trophy emoji or graphic. Give it 2 extra seconds — this is the payoff moment.

Pacing Checklist

IDEAL TIMELINE

0:00–0:04 Hook → 0:04–0:40 Round 1 (4 duels, ~9 sec each) → 0:40–1:05 Semi-Finals (2 matchups, ~12 sec each) → 1:05–1:22 Finale (17 sec) → 1:22–1:30 CTA (8 sec). **Total: ~90 seconds.** Anything over 100 seconds needs aggressive cuts.

CHAPTER 06

Distribution & Building a Series

Algorithm-Optimized Caption Formula

CAPTION TEMPLATE

"[WINNER] wins — no debate. 🏆 [Brief 1-sentence explanation of why]. Which one would YOU put in the final? Drop it in the comments 👇 "

Then add 3–5 targeted hashtags: 1 broad (#fitness, #crypto, #skincare), 1 niche-specific, 1 format-specific (#tournament #debate #ranking).

The question in the caption is mandatory. It's not decoration — it's an **engagement trigger**. Comments tell the algorithm the content is worth distributing.

Cross-Platform Strategy

- **TikTok:** Post at 7–9 PM. Use trending sounds if the bracket allows. Stitch-bait: "Stitch this if you disagree."
- **Instagram Reels:** Same video. Clean captions. Tag 2–3 brands (the contenders, if applicable) — they may repost.
- **YouTube Shorts:** Add a thumbnail. Title = your tournament question exactly. Helps search discovery.

Building a Tournament Series

> *"One tournament is a video. A series is an audience. The best creators film 4–8 in a weekend and post over a month."*

The series mechanic is simple: announce the next tournament at the end of every video. *"Tomorrow: the WORST investing advice on the internet. You won't like the answer."* This drives return visitors, saves, and follows.

5-WEEK CONTENT CALENDAR

Week 1 → Worst [bad thing in your niche] · Week 2 → Best [tool/habit/strategy] · Week 3 → Most overrated [popular thing] · Week 4 → Most underrated [hidden gem] · Week 5 → The one [thing] that beats all others. **Each title uses a different emotional trigger — fear, aspiration, contrarianism, discovery, authority.**

Tracking Performance

The metrics that matter for this format (in order of importance):

1. **Comment volume** — the primary signal this format drives
2. **Watch-through rate to finale** — measures bracket tension quality
3. **Shares** — indicates identity-resonance ("this is so me")
4. **Saves** — indicates the topic library content (niche ideas) is valuable

> **WHEN TO ITERATE**
>
> If comment volume is low, your verdict wasn't controversial enough — make a more divisive pick next time. If watch-through drops after Round 1, your pacing is too slow — cut harder. If shares are high but follows are low, your CTA isn't strong enough.

GO FILM IT

You Have Everything. Film Today.

Pick a niche. Pick a topic. Paste the prompt. Film. Post. The algorithm rewards those who act — not those who plan.

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